

Conflicts in the Middle East

The Middle East extends across West Asia to Egypt in North Africa. Many of the region's national borders were carelessly created by the British and French when they abandoned their colonies as their empires collapsed. The region has suffered frequent conflicts and upheavals throughout the 20th and early 21st centuries. These have included civil wars, religious conflicts, and invasions by foreign powers.

When Britain and France withdrew from the region in the 1940s, borders were haphazardly decided, and leaders loyal to the former rulers put in place. Palestine was divided into Jewish and Arab states and the Israel–Palestinian conflict remains unresolved today (see opposite).

Iraq and Egypt overthrew their kings, and Egypt's ruler Gamal Abdel Nasser provoked a failed British and French invasion after taking control of the Suez Canal. Iran and Iraq have also experienced frequent conflicts. Following the 1979 Iranian Revolution, Iraq invaded Iran in 1980. A million

people died during the war before a ceasefire was declared in 1988. On September 11, 2001, Islamic terrorist group “Al-Qaeda” carried out attacks in the US. The US responded with a “war on terror,” invading Afghanistan and Iraq to search for weapons that could destroy the West.

▼ ARAB SPRING

In 2010, Arabs across the region took part in uprisings, calling for more democratic rule from their governments. Egypt's President Mubarak was toppled, but little else was achieved in the region except more conflict, including the Syrian Civil War.

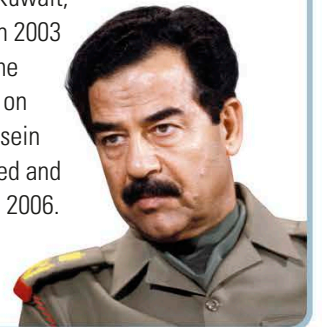


▲ IRANIAN REVOLUTION

In 1979, the Iranian people were unhappy with the ruling Shah (king) and his dependence on the West, particularly the US. A million people took to the streets to protest, forcing the Shah to step down and bringing Ayatollah Khomeini—an Islamic leader and figurehead of the revolution—to power.

SADDAM HUSSEIN

Saddam Hussein (ruled 1979–2003) led Iraq to war with Iran from 1980 to 1988, and in 1990 he invaded Kuwait. Iraq was invaded in 1991 by the US and its allies to liberate Kuwait, and again in 2003 as part of the wider “war on terror.” Hussein was captured and executed in 2006.



▲ THE IRAQ WAR

In 2003, the US invaded Iraq with support from the UK, Australia, and Poland. The Iraq War (2003–2011) was linked to the wider “war on terror” and began on the belief that Iraq had weapons of mass destruction which would be used against the West, though no weapons were found.

